OPEN-SOURCE INTELLIGENCE ASSESSMENT

Yandex Ablation: Did the Data-Center Strikes Silence Russian Information Operations?

A time-resolved attribution of the October 2026 drone strikes on Yandex data centers to Russian influence-operation output across Telegram, Reddit, the web and the Pravda network.

INDEPENDENT ANALYSIS | OPEN SOURCES ONLY

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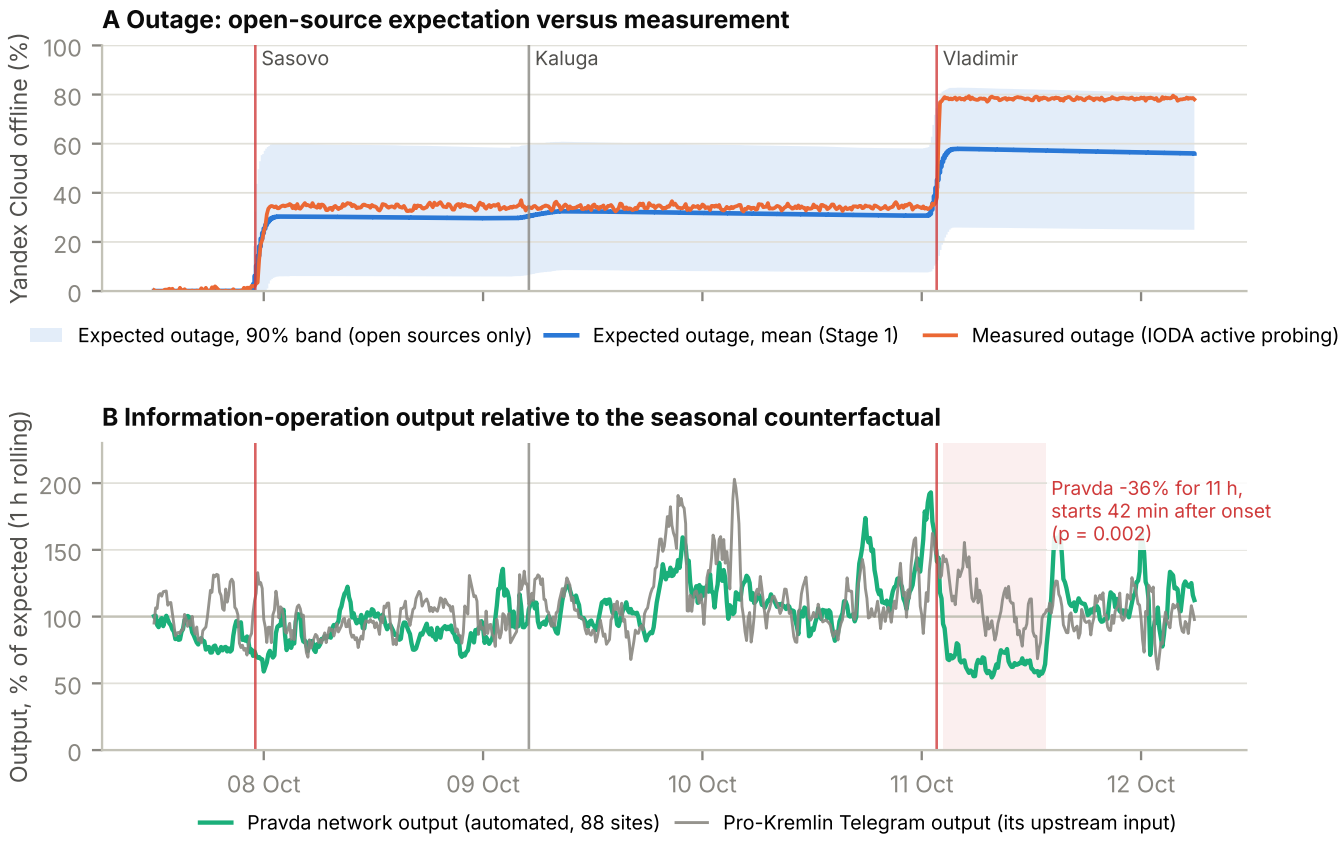
1. Bottom line

ANSWER

No broad reduction in Russian information operations is detectable. One automated pipeline, the Pravda network, stalled for 11 hours immediately after the Vladimir strike.

Probability	Key judgment
ALMOST CERTAIN	The strikes on Sasovo (night of 7 to 8 Oct) and Vladimir (11 Oct) removed about 38% and 53% of Yandex Cloud's externally reachable capacity; reachability fell to 22% of normal with no recovery by 13 Oct 12:00 UTC. The Kaluga strike (9 Oct) left no measurable cloud signature.
LIKELY	The Pravda network's publishing pipeline depended on infrastructure lost at Vladimir: output fell to 64% of expected for 11.2 h, starting 42 min after the measured outage onset (scan p = 0.002), with only 36% of the backlog published later. Its upstream Telegram sources did not dip.
VERY UNLIKELY	The strikes caused a broad reduction of Russian influence-operation output on social media, as claimed virally ("the bots went silent"). Across 76 channels, languages, communities and websites, no other platform group shows a credible drop; relative to controls, IO groups as a whole moved +11% (90% credible interval +3% to +19%), upward with strike news.
ALMOST CERTAIN	The viral "Russian bot traffic collapsed" chart counted automated web requests from Yandex's own network (AS13238), dominated by its search crawler, which stops when the data centers go dark. It is not evidence about social-media bots.

Figure 1. The only time-locked effect



A. The expected outage function estimated from published sources only (statements, status pages, satellite fire detections, complaint alerts) tracks the independently measured outage: onset errors of 2 min (Sasovo) and 18 min (Vladimir), 90% predictive coverage 99%. **B.** Pravda network output collapses within the hour after the Vladimir outage and recovers with a catch-up burst; its Telegram input does not. No comparable dip follows Sasovo, where the decline started 7 h before the strike. Shaded: most likely dip interval.

2. Approach

Question and design

Do the outages caused by the strikes coincide with a causally attributable reduction in Russian information-operation (IO) output, specifically on the theme of the war in Ukraine? The strikes are treated as a natural experiment with three treated events and one internal placebo (an unexplained Yandex Cloud reachability dip on 27 to 28 September). Each link of the causal chain (strike, capacity loss, dependent services, automated pipelines, social-media output) is measured separately so that a break is visible.

Expected outage function

A capacity-weighted damage model: every strike contributes a curve whose timing, onset lag, failure ramp, damage and recovery follow from graded reports. Source grades (Admiralty system) are converted into probabilities and pooled into each strike's credibility. The model is estimated in three nested Bayesian stages with adaptive-tempering sequential Monte Carlo: attack reports only (S0), all published information (S1), and fused with IODA active-probing telemetry (S2). Stage 1 is validated out of sample against the measurement.

Yandex dependency map

Public DNS (A, MX, NS) for 51 domains shows that no IO or state-media website is hosted on Yandex. Seven outlets run their mail on Yandex 360 (rt.com, vz.ru, readovka.news, rybar.ru, strategic-culture.su, topcor.ru, eadaily.com); their channels form a separate exposure stratum.

Outcomes and inference

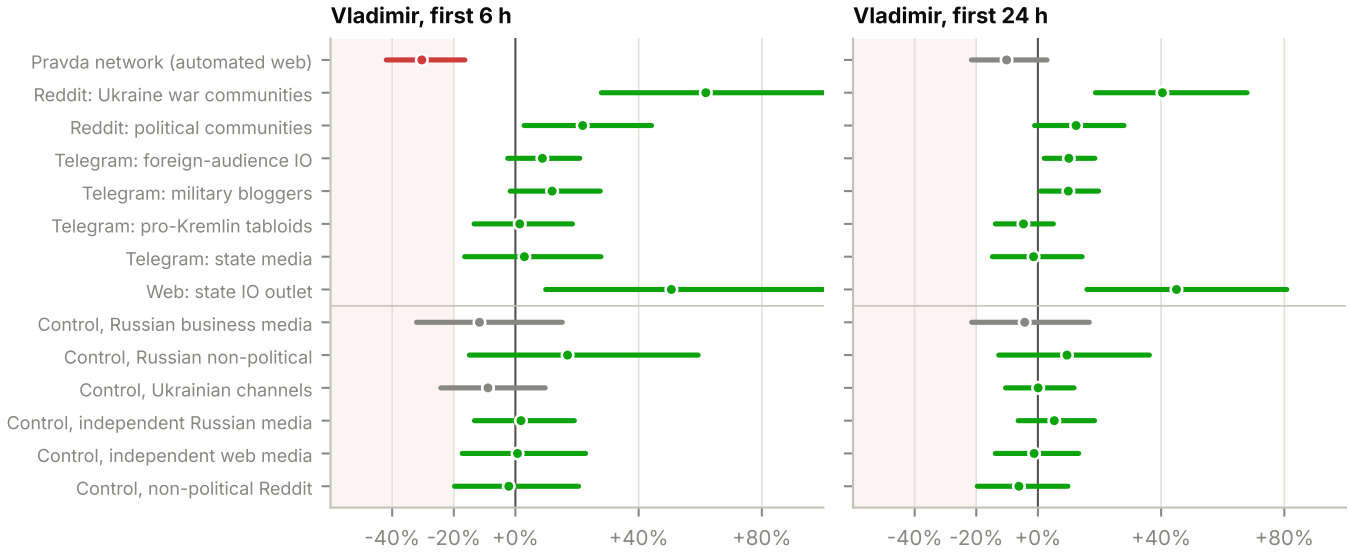
Hourly and 10-minute output of 221 series (107 IO output series plus controls, services and infrastructure): 806,762 Pravda articles on 88 sites; 46 Telegram channels (state, military bloggers, tabloids, foreign-audience IO, independent, Ukrainian and business controls); web publishing (ukraina.ru against two independent outlets); 18 Reddit communities and an account-level stream of r/UkraineRussiaReport. Each series gets an out-of-sample seasonal counterfactual. Inference combines:

- placebo-in-time windows (6 h and 24 h) and a seasonal-naive same-weekday check;
- a Bayesian hierarchical model pooling 76 member series into platform groups, with a Yandex-dependency term and common news-shock variance;
- 10-minute change-point dating of dips against the outage onset, calibrated with 400 placebo origins, and a backlog test;
- dose-response on the expected outage function with HAC errors, theme contrasts (war minus non-war), Benjamini-Hochberg FDR, a 20% equivalence bound, and analysis of competing hypotheses.

A drop counts as credible only if the posterior probability of a drop larger than 10% exceeds 90%, the group placebo p is below 0.05 and the seasonal-naive check agrees. A dip counts as time-locked only if it is significant and starts at or after the onset.

3. Results

Figure 2. Bayesian posterior change per platform group after the Vladimir strike



Posterior median and 90% credible interval. **Red**: credible drop. Green: drops larger than 20% ruled out. Grey: inconclusive. The red band marks drops beyond the 20% smallest effect of interest.

Platform group	n	Vladimir 6 h [90% CrI]	P(drop >10%)	Vladimir 24 h [90% CrI]	Credible drop
Pravda network (automated web)	13	-30% [-42%, -16%]	99%	-10% [-22%, +3%]	yes
Reddit: Ukraine war communities	6	+62% [+28%, +108%]	0%	+40% [+19%, +68%]	no
Reddit: political communities	6	+22% [+3%, +44%]	0%	+12% [-1%, +28%]	no
Telegram: foreign-audience IO	9	+9% [-2%, +21%]	0%	+10% [+2%, +18%]	no
Telegram: military bloggers	8	+12% [-2%, +28%]	0%	+10% [+1%, +20%]	no
Telegram: pro-Kremlin tabloids	4	+1% [-13%, +19%]	11%	-5% [-14%, +5%]	no
Telegram: state media	6	+3% [-16%, +28%]	14%	-1% [-15%, +14%]	no
Web: state IO outlet	1	+51% [+10%, +110%]	0%	+45% [+16%, +81%]	no
Control: Russian business media	3	-12% [-32%, +15%]	54%	-4% [-22%, +17%]	no
Control: Russian non-political	1	+17% [-15%, +59%]	9%	+9% [-13%, +36%]	no
Control: Ukrainian channels	6	-9% [-24%, +10%]	46%	+0% [-11%, +12%]	no
Control: independent Russian media	5	+2% [-13%, +19%]	11%	+5% [-6%, +18%]	no
Control: independent web media	2	+1% [-17%, +23%]	17%	-1% [-14%, +13%]	no
Control: non-political Reddit	6	-2% [-20%, +20%]	25%	-6% [-20%, +10%]	no

Infrastructure and services

Yandex Cloud: 23:04 UTC onset after Sasovo (strike 22:27, full loss 00:24); 01:38 UTC after Vladimir (strike 00:10). BGP visibility stayed intact (a data-plane loss). Hosting, access and platform controls (Selectel, Timeweb, Beget, VK, Rostelecom, MTS, MegaFon, Beeline, Yandex Cloud Kazakhstan) show no matching steps. Russian Wikipedia user traffic fell -7% in 24 h after Vladimir, consistent with Yandex Search and app disruption; complaint alerts for Yandex Pay, Go and KinoPoisk surged from 00:47 UTC.

Where an IO effect is and is not seen

- **Pravda network:** the only credible, time-locked drop (Vladimir 6 h -30%). English, German and French sites dip 22 min after onset.
- Telegram state media, military bloggers, tabloids and foreign-audience IO (InfoDefense, Strategic Culture, Sputnik Africa, Rybar, Slavyangrad, embassy): no credible drop.
- Topic substitution, not capacity loss: non-war posts of state (-26%) and tabloid channels (-19%) fell after Vladimir while their war posts rose (+14%, +17%) and their totals did not change significantly.
- Outlets on Yandex 360 mail: extra effect -8% (90% -18% to +3%), no different from the -7% seen in the placebo window.
- Web (ukraina.ru) and Reddit (pro-Russian, war and the political communities named in viral claims): no drop; war communities rose with strike news. No war-specific reduction anywhere.

Overall tally (Vladimir, 24 h)

Of 107 IO series, 51 rule out a drop larger than 20%, 33 are inconclusive, 19 increased and 4 show an FDR-significant drop that survives the seasonal-naive check (Pravda network: language ro; Pravda network: news-pravda.com; Pro-Kremlin state channels (other posts); Pro-Kremlin tabloids (other posts)); the Telegram cases are topic substitution (above).

Analysis of competing hypotheses

A narrow dependency of specific automated pipelines (H2) carries no weighted inconsistency. A broad IO collapse (H1) is contradicted by every platform-level measurement. "No IO effect" (H3) is contradicted only by the Pravda dip.

Limitations

- X, VK and closed bot infrastructure are not observable with open data; small dedicated networks could go undetected (median single-series minimum detectable drop about 26% over 24 h, 10 to 20% for pooled groups).
- The strikes were themselves major news, inflating war-related activity; theme contrasts and controls mitigate but cannot remove this.
- Pravda attribution rests on timing. Its sites sit behind Cloudflare, so hosting is not directly observable, and Sasovo, which removed 38% of cloud capacity, produced no time-locked dip.
- Sanctioned outlets blocked by the national resolver (RT, Sputnik, RIA) were mapped through public DNS but not crawled. Recovery estimates are right-censored.

Principal sources

Yandex Cloud status incidents 2092 and 2136 and incident API (status.yandex.cloud); Yandex Telegram posts 5900 to 5905; Vladimir governor post 10997; IODA raw signals (Georgia Tech); RIPE Stat; NASA FIRMS VIIRS; Cloudflare Radar and NetBlocks posts (Bluesky); Detector404 and Sboy.rf alerts; Wikimedia pageviews API; Pravda network, ukraina.ru, zona.media and theins.ru sitemaps; Telegram public previews; Arctic Shift Reddit archive; public DNS via 1.1.1.1, 8.8.8.8, 9.9.9.9. Methods: Del Moral, Doucet and Jasra (2006); Brodersen et al. (2015); Newey and West (1987); Benjamini and Hochberg (1995); DerSimonian and Laird (1986); Gelman and Rubin (1992); Lakens (2017); Heuer (1999); ICD 203; NATO AJP-2.1. Interactive dashboard, code and pipeline: OSINT_YandexOutage repository.